

BJP courts women voters through common civil code

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India's ruling Bharatiya Janata Party has announced plans to implement a Uniform Civil Code ahead of the 2029 general election, a move it believes will|||||||

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India

Short-term trajectory:

Long-term trajectory:

Trade deals with Canada, EU likely by year-end as US negotiations slow. Although both Indian and US officials have stated that the US-India trade deal is almost final, neither side appears to be in a hurry to sign it. Meanwhile, India's trade agreements with Canada and the EU are likely to be completed by the end of the year.

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India is comfortable with the current US 10% tariff level and has decided to wait for the US's forthcoming Section 301 overcapacity tariffs. It has little incentive to rush negotiations, as rupee depreciation against the dollar has softened the impact of the 10% tariff on Indian industry. Even once the overcapacity tariffs are imposed, India is expected to retain its tariff advantage over its primary competitors, China and Vietnam.

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Pressure to conclude the agreement from President Donald Trump has also waned after India significantly ramped up energy purchases from the US (partly to diversify energy imports away from the Persian Gulf), finalized a series of defense deals, and pledged to invest \$20 billion in the US (see: US and India in no hurry to finalize trade deal , 9 September 2026).

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India-Canada trade negotiations continue apace. The latest round of talks is being held in New Delhi from 14 to 18 September, with Canadian Trade Minister Maninder Sidhu also visiting India on 18 and 19 September to advance negotiations. In August, the two countries held their inaugural Finance Ministers' Economic and Financial Dialogue, where India offered to begin negotiations on a new Bilateral Investment Treaty.

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The legal text of the EU-India trade agreement has been finalized and was submitted to the European Council for its assent on 11 September. A subsequent vote by the European Parliament will pave the way for its implementation. The released text of the agreement increases Indian steel access to the EU, although Indian exporters will still be subject to the EU's carbon tax. Meanwhile, the EU will gain greater market access for automobiles.

New Delhi keeps BRICS neutral, but will struggle to contain China's influence within the grouping. India managed to avoid any controversies at the BRICS summit it hosted between 11 and 13 September. New Delhi's key accomplishment at the summit was a joint statement endorsed by both Iran and the UAE despite the hostility between them. This was accomplished by persuading the two to agree to language that criticized Israel by name for military action against Lebanon and expressed concerns about strikes on nuclear targets, but only those under international safeguards.

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The joint statement also criticized "aggression" in generic terms without naming the US, as India was wary of provoking Trump at a time when US-India relations are stable. Trump has often complained about the BRICS, particularly over measures that could reduce the BRICS countries' reliance on the US dollar.

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India and China continued their detente, with Prime Minister Narendra Modi and President Xi Jinping holding a bilateral meeting on the sidelines of the summit, though the meeting did not yield any significant outcomes. India-China ties are expected to remain stable over the next year, but the underlying rivalry will place limits on the relationship.

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India prevented China from elevating its already dominant position in the BRICS at the summit, particularly by ensuring the grouping did not move toward centralized financial and trade integration. However, in the longer term, New Delhi will struggle to resist Beijing's use of the forum to spread Chinese digital platforms and standards, especially as China hosts the BRICS summit next year (see: BRICS summit sets stage for China's digital standards push , 15 September 2026).

BJP aiming to boost support among women with common civil code. On 13 September, Home Minister Amit Shah announced that the 21 states governed by the ruling Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) and its allies will implement a Uniform Civil Code (UCC) before the general elections in 2029. Key coalition partners, including the Telugu Desam Party, which governs Andhra Pradesh, have expressed support for the move, though the Janata Dal (United), a junior partner of the BJP in Bihar, has been cautious in its response.

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The idea behind a UCC is to establish a set of common personal laws governing areas such as marriage and inheritance. Currently, different religious communities in India are governed by laws based on their respective scriptures.

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Enacting a UCC is a long-standing ideological goal of the BJP, and the ruling party believes it will bolster its support among women, as it will grant them equal inheritance rights, standardize marital consent, strengthen divorce procedures, and codify alimony standards. Religious minorities, particularly Muslims, and tribal communities have opposed the move, with the latter expected to secure exemptions.

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The Modi government is opting to first have states governed by the BJP and its allies introduce their own UCCs, with the central government then likely to pass an overarching law. The BJP believes that reaching a national consensus would be too challenging. A state-by-state strategy offers more flexibility and enables the ruling party to experiment with different models. Four states—Uttarakhand, Gujarat, Assam, and Madhya Pradesh—have passed UCC bills, but only Uttarakhand has implemented its code.

Launch of satellite communication services inches closer. The Ministry of Communication has approved most of the telecom regulator's recommendations on the pricing and allocation of radio waves for satellite communication (satcom). It settled on a 5% adjusted gross revenue charge (4% in remote areas) as a spectrum fee for satcom operators. The final approval now rests with Modi's cabinet.

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Once cleared, the government will administratively allocate satellite spectrum to operators such as Starlink, Reliance's Jio Satellite Communications, and the Bharti Group-backed Eutelsat OneWeb, enabling the launch of satcom services in the country.

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All three players have been granted satcom permits and authorization from the space regulator, though they still need security clearance from the Home Ministry. Starlink will also need FDI approval from the government, given its 100% foreign ownership structure. Amazon Leo has yet to secure any approvals.

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The introduction of satellite communication services will help extend internet connectivity to remote and underserved areas in the country but is unlikely to have much impact in urban areas.

Pakistan

Short-term trajectory:

Long-term trajectory:

Proposal to create new provinces likely shelved for now. Fears of demonstrations, particularly in Sindh province, have prompted the government to put off a proposal to reorganize the country's administrative structure. On 1 September, Planning Minister Ahsan Iqbal called for either the creation of 15 new provinces or the establishment of 160 empowered district governments to improve governance. Interior Minister Mohsin Naqvi has also advocated for a similar restructuring, but neither minister provided any additional details.

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The reorganization proposal is understood to have originated from the military, with backing from the country's de facto leader, Field Marshal Asim Munir. Although it enjoys support within the civilian and military bureaucracy and some smaller political parties, it has met resistance from the country's two largest parties—the ruling Pakistan Muslim League (Nawaz) (PML-N) and its junior coalition partner, the Pakistan People's Party (PPP)—as it would undermine their political influence.

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The PPP, which derives its power from Sindh, has vehemently opposed splitting the province, with the Sindh provincial assembly even passing a resolution against the measure. Meanwhile, the PML-N, whose base is in Punjab, is internally divided on the issue. Punjab Chief Minister Maryam Nawaz, who is also Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif's niece, is reportedly opposed to the province's division.

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Given that the measure requires both a two-thirds majority in parliament and provincial assemblies, it is unlikely to pass without support from the PML-N and PPP. However, the proposal is unlikely to go away and may be used to build pressure for devolving power to local governments.

Eurobond sale will help IMF review. Pakistan raised \$3 billion through a Eurobond sale on 2 September. The dual-tranche deal comprised \$1.75 billion for five-and-a-half years at 7.5% and \$1.25 billion for ten years at 7.9%. This marks the country's official return to international capital markets after about four-and-a-half years. Pakistan had previously raised \$750 million privately through a Eurobond in April and \$250 million through a yuan-denominated Panda bond in May.

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The bond sale was made possible by upgrades from rating agencies. Last year, S&P and Fitch upgraded Pakistan to B-, and S&P further upgraded the country to B in July. Moody's upgraded Pakistan to B3 a week before the bond issuance. The ratings upgrades, coupled with the Eurobond sale, indicate that international investors believe the risk of a near-term balance-of-payments crisis has receded.

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The Eurobond issuance will not resolve the economy's structural problems. However, it will bolster Pakistan's foreign exchange reserves, which reached \$18.3 billion on 4 September, providing nearly three months of import cover. It will also help meet debt repayments and reduce reliance on short-term bilateral rollovers. Its overall value will depend on whether the government uses the proceeds to refinance more expensive short-term obligations rather than putting them toward additional spending.

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The bond sale will make it easier for Pakistan to meet the IMF's reserve accumulation and external financing targets ahead of its forthcoming review. Still, a substantial revenue shortfall, delays in implementing economic governance and anticorruption reforms, and government intervention in commodity markets remain key challenges. The IMF is expected to begin the next review of Pakistan's \$7 billion Extended Fund Facility and \$1.4 billion Resilience and Sustainability Facility on 23 September. A successful review would unlock a combined \$1.2 billion.

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